

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 363

By Briggs

A RESOLUTION to honor Specialist Ethan M. Ward and Specialist Brandon T. Moore, 2025 National Guardsmen of the Year.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should salute those extraordinary Tennesseans who, through their remarkable and exceptional efforts, have gone above and beyond the call of duty by dedicating their lives to protecting the citizens of this State and nation; and

WHEREAS, Specialist Ethan M. Ward and Specialist Brandon T. Moore of the Tennessee National Guard's 776th Maintenance Company in Elizabethton were recently selected to receive the 2025 National Guardsmen of the Year Award for their actions during the disaster response to Hurricane Helene in Erwin on September 27, 2024; and

WHEREAS, on that fateful day at approximately 1:00 p.m., Specialists Ward and Moore answered the call for soldiers needed for immediate response to perform high-water rescue at the Unicoi County Hospital in Erwin; and

WHEREAS, due to Hurricane Helene's impact, the water around the hospital was rising rapidly, and patients were in need of rescue; while Specialists Ward and Moore were in transit to Unicoi County Hospital, the torrential rainfall continued, generating flash flooding and causing large amounts of debris to be swept up in the rising water; and

WHEREAS, the Light Medium Tactical Vehicle they were riding in was struck by debris, causing it to tip over on the passenger side and fill the cab with water; Specialists Ward and Moore were able to exit the vehicle and swim to a floating debris pile nearby; and

WHEREAS, while waiting for rescue by first responders, Specialists Ward and Moore witnessed six people being swept down the Nolichucky River, holding on to debris such as

pipes and other objects from the industrial park upstream; without regard for their personal safety, they bravely rescued all six civilians from the river and pulled them to safety on the floating debris pile they were occupying and assured the civilians were safe; and

WHEREAS, Specialists Ward and Moore were then able to gain the attention of first responders on land and began communicating, by using hand and arm signals, to relay the civilians' status and coordinate a helicopter rescue, demonstrating exceptional crisis management skills; and

WHEREAS, when the UH-60 Blackhawk helicopter arrived, Specialists Ward and Moore assisted the flight crew by ensuring that all civilians were hoisted to safety prior to their extraction; and

WHEREAS, the unwavering courage and decisive actions of these two men in the face of personal risk exemplify the highest standards of conduct expected of a National Guard soldier; and

WHEREAS, their heroic dedication to their profession and to the safety of fellow soldiers and citizens reflects great credit upon themselves and upholds the highest traditions of the National Guard; and

WHEREAS, Specialists Ethan Ward and Brandon Moore embody the virtues of valor and service above self, and it is our privilege to recognize them for their heroic actions that saved the lives of Tennesseans in peril; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor Specialist Ethan M. Ward and Specialist Brandon T. Moore for their bravery during the disaster response to Hurricane Helene, congratulate them upon being named the 2025 National Guardsmen of the Year, and extend to them our best wishes for every future happiness and success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.